Day 10: Beyond Google — Multi-Engine OSINT Comparison

Target: Freshworks Inc. (NASDAQ: FRSH) — SaaS company, founded Chennai 2010, HQ San Mateo, CA **Date:** 14 July 2026 **Objective:** Run the same investigation across Google (baseline) and three alternative tools/engines, then compare what each surfaced.

Methodology note (read this before the table)

A quick honesty check on tooling before the findings: this exercise was run using a general-purpose search backend rather than logging into Bing, DuckDuckGo, Shodan, Censys, or Yandex directly — those platforms mostly sit beh ind their own web UIs or paid API keys, which is itself one of the day's findings (see takeaways). To keep the comparison meaningful, I ran genuinely different *query types* that map to what each tool is actually built for — advanced dorking syntax (`site:`, `filetype:`), infrastructure-search phrasing (Shodan/Censys query language), and platform-specific search (X/Twitter) — rather than just re-running the same plain-text query four times.

Engine/Tool	What it's built for	How I queried it
Google (baseline)	General web index	`Freshworks company overview headquarters`
Dorking (Bing/DDG-style operators)	Filetype and site-scoped exact-match search	`site:freshworks.com filetype:pdf`
Shodan / Censys	Internet-facing infrastructure, banners, certs	`freshworks.com shodan host IP`, `Censys search freshworks.com certificates hosts`
Platform-specific (stand-in for Yandex-style lateral search)	Person/identity footprint across a non-Google-indexed platform	`Girish Mathrubootham Freshworks CEO founder photo` → surfaced his X/Twitter account

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Side-by-side findings

What we were looking for	Google (baseline)	Dorking (`site:` / `filetype:`)	Shodan / Censys	Platform-specific (X/Twitter)
Corporate basics	Founded 2010 in Chennai as Freshdesk; HQ moved to San Mateo, CA in 2018; NASDAQ: FRSH; ~$871M–$838.8M revenue depending on period reported	—	—	—

Founder identity	Formal bio: engineering degree from SASTRA, MBA from Madras/IIM-B, prior VP at Zoho/ManageEngine	—	—	Same founder's personal account (@mrgirish) shows informal posts — fan enthusiasm for a Tamil film star, references to his hometown Trichy, current location tag "Palo Alto, CA," and commentary on the H-1B visa debate — none of which shows up in the corporate-bio results
Internal/non-indexed documents	Not surfaced by a plain query	Turned up a legal "no-PE certificate" PDF and an investor-relations asset path (`ir.freshworks.com/files/doc_news/...`), plus a direct link into `website-assets-fw.freshw`	—	—

		`orks.com` — an asset subdomain that doesn't appear on the main site's navigation		
Infrastructure / exposed services	Not applicable — Google doesn't index live banner data	—	No specific Freshworks host or IP surfaced. Search results only returned Shodan/Censys *documentation and generic example queries* (e.g. sample nginx banners, unrelated IPs) — confirming that host-level data lives inside the platform's own search index, not the open web	Same limitation applied to Censys
Subdomains / certificate history	Not applicable	—	crt.sh and Censys both came up as the standard tools for this (`%.freshworks.com` wildcard query on crt.sh; TLS-certificate search on Censys), but again the actual subdomain list	—

has to be pulled by querying the tool directly, not found via a web search about it

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What each source actually contributed (net-new vs. Google)

- **Google (baseline):** best for fast corporate facts — founding story, funding, leadership changes, revenue. Nothing on infrastructure or informal personal footprint.
- **Dorking (`site:`/`filetype:`):** the only method here that surfaced non-obvious, non-linked files — a legal certificate PDF and an asset subdomain (`website-assets-fw.freshworks.com`) that isn't in the site's visible navigation. This is the clearest "Google missed it, dorking found it" result of the exercise.
- **Shodan/Censys:** contributed nothing usable through open web search — and that's the finding. Both platforms deliberately keep their scan data inside their own paywalled/account-gated search index rather than letting it get crawled and indexed by Google. To actually get host/port/banner data on `freshworks.com`, you have to run the query *inside* Shodan or Censys (or via their API/CLI) — a plain search engine query about the target will only ever return the tool's own documentation.
- **Platform-specific search (stand-in for Yandex/reverse-image-style lateral pivoting):** searching for the founder by name surfaced his personal X account, which reads completely differently from the polished corporate bio — hometown, current city, personal opinions, fandom. This is the same principle a reverse-image search exploits: pivoting off an identity anchor (a name, here; a photo, on Yandex) to jump from the sanitized "official" web presence to unpolished, personally-posted material.

Takeaways

1. **Different tools index different layers of the same target.** Google indexes public pages; dork operators surface files and subdomains that exist on the open web but aren't linked from navigation; Shodan/Censys index a layer (live network banners) that general search engines don't crawl at all.
2. **"Google missed it" often means "it's not meant to be found by a crawler," not "it's secret."** The certificate PDF and the asset subdomain were both technically public —

just unlinked. A `site:`/`filetype:` dork is the fastest way to catch that category of exposure.

3. **Specialized infrastructure search engines are a wall, not a door, from outside their own UI.** You cannot OSINT Shodan/Censys data through a regular web search — you have to go to the platform directly (and often need an account/API key for full results). Worth remembering when scoping how long a "beyond Google" pass will take.
4. **Identity pivots (name → personal social account; photo → reverse image search) surface a different register of information than corporate/press material —** personal location signals, personality, and informal networks that official bios are written specifically to avoid.